

PART II

A FRAMEWORK FOR TYPOLOGICAL INTERPRETATION

We survey some of the main biblical doctrines that offer a framework for interpreting types.

4

Basic Theology for Typology

IN PREPARATION FOR VENTURING into the details of types and the details of biblical passages, we should survey the larger framework for biblical interpretation. We must refer people to other books for a more thorough discussion of the larger issues of interpretation.¹ But we may mention some particular principles that have an important influence as we come to study typology.

God as Ruler

¹ Vern S. Poythress, *God-Centered Biblical Interpretation* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 1999); Vern S. Poythress, *Reading the Word of God in the Presence of God: A Handbook for Biblical Interpretation* (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2016). On types in the Pentateuch, see Vern S. Poythress, *The Shadow of Christ in the Law of Moses* (repr., Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 1995). For a short introduction, see Iain Duguid, *Is Christ in the Old Testament?* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 2013).

Since typology studies connections between earlier and later events in history, we have to understand something about the nature of history. So the first principle of importance is that God rules history. He rules it from the very beginning and forever into the future:

Lord, you have been our dwelling place
in all generations.
Before the mountains were brought forth,
or ever you had formed the earth and the world,
from *everlasting to everlasting* you are God. (Ps. 90:1–2)

Remember this and stand firm,
recall it to mind, you transgressors,
remember the former things of old;
for I am God, and there is no other;
I am God, and there is none like me,
declaring *the end from the beginning*
and from ancient times things not yet done,
saying, “My counsel shall stand,
and I will accomplish all my purpose.” (Isa. 46:8–10)

God works out both the great sweep of historical development and every minuscule event within it:

Who has spoken and it came to pass,
unless the Lord has commanded it?
Is it not from the mouth of the Most High
that good and bad come? (Lam. 3:37–38)

In him we have obtained an inheritance, having been predestined according to the purpose of him who works *all things* according to the counsel of his will, ... (Eph. 1:11)

Are not two sparrows sold for a penny? And not one of them will fall to the ground apart from your Father. But even the hairs of your head are all numbered. Fear not, therefore; you are of more value than many sparrows. (Matt. 10:29–31)

God has a plan encompassing all of history:

“*My counsel* shall stand,
and I will accomplish *all my purpose*, ...” (Isa. 46:10)

... the *purpose* of him who works all things according to *the counsel of his will*. (Eph. 1:11)

His plan is to sum up all things in Christ:

... as a plan for the fullness of time, to *unite all things in him* [Christ], things in heaven and things on earth. (Eph. 1:10)

So there is a unity to God's plan. Earlier and later events are connected, even across vast stretches of time, because God is orchestrating all events for his own glory (Eph. 1:6, 12) and for the blessing of his people (Eph. 1:22–23; Rom. 8:28).

The Outline of History: Creation, Fall, Redemption, and Consummation

Every particular event in history has meaning given by God in his plan. Every event is related to every other event within a vast panorama. God alone knows his plan comprehensively. But he reveals key aspects of his plan to us, through what he says in the Bible.

We can therefore obtain from the Bible a basic outline of history. History consists in creation, fall, redemption, and consummation.

God has a plan, before history ever begins.

As the first step in executing his plan, there is creation. God creates the world (Gen. 1). As a climactic act of creation, he creates mankind in Adam (vv. 26–27).

Second, there is the fall. Adam and Eve fall into sin after being tempted by the serpent (Gen. 3).

Third, God works redemption. Beginning with the promise of redemption in Genesis 3:15, God speaks and acts over a long period of time to begin to work out his plan for redeeming human beings from their sin, guilt, and alienation from him. God's works of redemption, together with his words explaining his works, extend from Genesis through the whole history of the Old Testament. All of this history is leading up to Christ. Christ comes into the world in his incarnation. He takes on our human nature. But, unlike us, he is perfectly obedient and without sin. His righteousness substitutes for our unrighteousness. As the bearer of our sins, he suffers and is put to death on the cross. He rises on the third day for our justification (Rom. 4:25). He ascends to heaven and rules from there (Eph. 1:20–22).

All of this is the grand story of redemption. The process extends from the fall onward, but it comes to its definitive climax in the work of Christ on earth. He has defeated death and sin and the devil once and for all. We now await his return.

Fourth, there is the consummation, still to come.² The consummation, the new

² Premillennialists teach about a distinct epoch, which they associate with the “millennium,” in

heaven and the new earth ([Rev. 21:1](#)), represents the final stage of history. Sin and death are completely eliminated in the new world. The saints enjoy the presence of God forever ([Rev. 22:1–5](#)). The consummation can be treated as the final stage of redemption. But it goes on forever, after redemption is completed. So it is aptly considered to be a fourth stage, in addition to creation, fall, and redemption.

Old Testament and New Testament

Within this grand outline, we can make a further distinction between the Old Testament period of redemption (from the fall onward) and the New Testament period (beginning with the announcement of the kingdom of God by John the Baptist). The major division is found in the coming of Christ. Everything before his coming is leading up to his coming. Everything after his first coming is built on what he achieved in that first coming. It is also looking forward to his second coming.

Already and Not Yet

It has become customary to speak of “already” and “not yet.” Already Christ has come. Already he has defeated death in his resurrection. Already he has poured out the Holy Spirit and commissioned his disciples to spread the gospel to all nations. Already, in union with Christ, we have eternal life ([John 6:35, 40, 47–51; 11:25–26](#)). But all of this has not yet been wrapped up, as it will be in the consummation. What remains is called “not yet,” or (more positively) “yet to come.”

Accordingly, there are several aspects of the application of redemption that are spoken of both as already here and as still to come. For example, we are already adopted as sons ([Rom. 8:15–17; Gal. 4:5–7](#)), but the fullness of adoption is yet to come ([Rom. 8:23](#)). We have eternal life now ([John 6:47](#)), but the resurrection of the body remains future ([vv. 39–40](#)).

Movements within the Old Testament

We may also observe major movements in the history of redemption that take place within the Old Testament period. Noah’s flood marks a watershed. So does the call of Abraham, the exodus under Moses, the establishment of the monarchy with David (after Saul’s failure), the exile, and the restoration from exile (Ezra). All of these stages take place according to God’s plan. Each of them has a distinctive flavor. But God’s unified plan for salvation remains the same. Through the whole Old Testament, generation

between the second coming of Christ and the creation of the new heaven and the new earth.

after generation of people find salvation by believing in God's promise of a Savior who will accomplish climactic salvation. All the stages are moving forward toward this climax.

Meaning within History

Each event in history, such as the preservation of Noah in the flood, and the lifting up of the bronze serpent in [Numbers 21](#), has meaning in the mind of God. Each event fits into his overall plan. Each event takes place within the context of creation, which has preceded it. Each event is part of a sequence leading to the consummation, which sums up the meaning of it all in Christ ([Eph. 1:10](#)).

Each event in the middle period, the period of redemption, has a role in the working of God's purposes of redemption. The Bible records both events of deliverance and salvation and events of judgment and destruction. Events of salvation look forward to climactic salvation in Christ. Instances of judgment look forward to the last judgment ([Rev. 20:11–15](#)). Also, Christ in his death bore judgment on behalf of sinners. Each event is related to the work of Christ, who is the center. We may not be able to discern this meaning. The meaning is ultimately God's meaning, not ours. And God is infinite. But by instructing us about his plan in the Bible, God does show us aspects of his purposes.

The Role of the Bible

What part does the Bible play in God's plan for history? God acts in history. God also speaks in history. He spoke to Adam and Eve ([Gen. 3](#)). He spoke to Noah ([6:13–21](#)). He spoke to Abraham ([12:1–3](#)). He spoke to Moses ([Ex. 3](#)). These words were passed on to their descendants. In addition, God caused his words to be written down, as we see with the Ten Commandments and Moses's writings ([Deut. 31:9, 24–26](#)). Over time, God caused more books to be added. The result is now the completed canon of Scripture. The Bible is the very word of God ([2 Tim. 3:16](#); [2 Pet. 1:21](#)). God designed it to have a central role in guiding our lives ([Ps. 119:105](#); [Matt. 4:4](#)).

As a result, it is to the Bible that we turn in order to understand the meaning of the Old Testament. The general principle is that Scripture interprets Scripture. What is said in one place in the Bible helps us to understand better what is said in other places. The Bible is in one way a single book, because it has a single divine author, namely God, who wrote it over a period of centuries to be a permanent guide for us. It is also many books, written by a number of distinct human authors. God raised up each distinctive human author with his own distinctive personality and his own distinctive gifts. So we should pay attention to each human author in his distinctiveness. But we pay primary attention

to God, who guided each human author: “For no prophecy was ever produced by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit” (2 Pet. 1:21). It is appropriate, therefore, for us to use the whole Bible when we are trying to appreciate more deeply the implications of any one passage from any one book of the Bible.

Progressive Revelation

The Bible and the history of redemption go together, according to the unified plan of God. God’s work of redemption in history, and God’s *words* in history, go together in harmony. As one aspect of this joint work, God spread out his words over time. He did not reveal the whole Bible for all time suddenly to Adam and Eve. He did reveal some aspects of the promise of redemption in Genesis 3:15, but more revelation was to follow. We must respect this progressive character of the working of redemption, and with it respect the progressive character of God’s speech. He shows more and more, over time, as he speaks through the centuries, through different human authors and prophets.

What is added in later parts of the Old Testament, and then what is added in the New Testament, is not merely more bits of information. Certainly there *is* more information. But later words often spiral back around the themes of earlier words. They enrich the understanding of themes already mentioned, rather than merely adding some new theme with no relation to what came earlier. This enrichment is more challenging than if God had just added new bits, unrelated to the old. But it is in accord with the unity of his plan. God in fact is surveying his *whole* plan, rather than just small bits, when he gives the promise in Genesis 3:15. Later revelation does not change the whole plan, but it does enrich our understanding of it. The enrichment is often holistic, not merely adding an isolated new bit.

In the time of the Old Testament, God is already at work to save a people for his own possession (Gen. 4:26; 5:22–24; 6:9; 12:1–3; Ex. 19:5–6). He shows them enough about himself and his ways so that they can trust him and be saved. So it is natural that his communication to them would be holistic. After all, his saving relation to them is holistic. He promises Abraham and his offspring that he will “be God to you” (Gen. 17:7).

God establishes a multifaceted, rich personal relation with his people. It has many implications. The implications *in detail* are only gradually revealed, over time. This gradual work is called *progressive revelation*. God himself designed revelation to have this progressive character. Therefore, the earlier revelations do not have any faults in them, contrary to what some people have alleged. The earlier revelations are exactly what God wants, each one appropriate to its particular time in the history of redemp-

tion. But each one is *incomplete* in comparison with the history as a whole. And the people at the earlier times would have intuitively sensed that it was incomplete. For them much was still mysterious, and the promises of God are magnificent in their scope.

A Summary by G. K. Beale

G. K. Beale aptly summarizes this whole theological framework in a few sentences, as follows:

... there is one grand assumption of all: Jesus and the apostles believed that the OT Scriptures were “sacred” and were the Word of God. Therefore all authoritative theological discussion had to be based on and proceed from this sacred body of literature....

1. There is the apparent assumption of *corporate solidarity* or *representation*.
2. In the light of corporate solidarity or representation, Christ as the Messiah is viewed as representing the *true Israel* of the OT *and* the true Israel—the church—in the NT.
3. *History is unified* by a wise and sovereign plan so that the earlier parts are designed to correspond and point to the later parts (cf., e.g., [Matt. 5:17](#); [11:13](#); [13:16–17](#)).
4. The age of *eschatological fulfillment* has come in Christ.
5. As a consequence of the preceding presupposition, it follows that the later parts of biblical history function as the broader context for interpreting earlier parts because they all have the same, ultimate divine author who inspires the various human authors. One deduction from this premise is that Christ is the goal toward which the OT pointed and is the end-time center of redemptive history, which is the *key to interpreting the earlier portions of the OT and its promises*.³

³ G. K. Beale, *Handbook on the New Testament Use of the Old Testament* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, 2012), [95–97](#), emphasis original.

The Shape of Our Response to the Bible

OUR INTERPRETATIONS OF TYPOLOGY should fit into a broader context of how we respond to God and to his word. We will briefly consider our response using three perspectives on ethics: [the normative perspective](#), [the situational perspective](#), and [the existential perspective](#).

The Three Perspectives on Ethics

As developed by John Frame, the three perspectives on ethics each look at the whole field of ethics, but in three distinct ways.¹ The normative perspective focuses on *norms*. These are found in the contents of Scripture. (Conscience is a kind of subordinate norm, but due to the corruption of sin, it is no longer fully reliable.) The situational perspective focuses on *the situation*. It asks concerning the situation, “What will promote the glory of God within the situation?” The existential perspective, also called the personal perspective, focuses on the *persons* and their attitudes and motives. So each individual asks, “What are my motives, and what should they be, in guiding my thoughts and actions?” According to this third view, the primary motive should be love.

These three perspectives imply one another; in a sense, they include each other. For example, if we pay careful attention to the moral standards in the Bible, which are in focus in the normative perspective, we find that these standards tell us to have the motive of love, which is in focus in the existential perspective. The standards also tell us that we should pay attention to the situation in order better to understand our neighbor’s needs and to love him effectively. So if we diligently follow the normative perspective, we will find within that perspective that it tells us to begin using the situational and existential perspectives.

Or suppose that we start with the existential perspective. We should have the motive of love. And if we do, and we love God, we will pay attention to what he says. So we will develop the normative perspective. If we love our neighbor, it leads us to pay attention

¹ John M. Frame, “A Primer on Perspectivalism (Revised 2008),” §7, www.frame-poythress.org; John M. Frame, *Perspectives on the Word of God: An Introduction to Christian Ethics* (repr., Eugene, OR: Wipf & Stock, 1999); John M. Frame, *The Doctrine of the Christian Life* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 2008).

to his situation in order to help. So we will develop the situational perspective.

Thus the three perspectives are perspectives on the whole challenge of how to think and act in the presence of God, who governs all three perspectives.

The Normative Perspective for Bible Study

We may now apply all three of these perspectives to see their implications for the study of typology. Actually, the three perspectives have something to say about how we interpret the Bible in general, not just about how we interpret passages that may include types.

First, in the normative perspective, we focus on God and his norms, which are in the Bible. In a typical study of the Bible, we have before us one main passage, such as the passage in [Genesis 6:9–22](#) leading to Noah’s flood. We have to pay attention to the passage. We are supposed to submit to what it says, as a norm. We take care not merely to avoid injecting our own ideas, but to listen to what God says. So we will not do as Philo did, by importing his own ideas about spiritual generation of virtues.

The Situational Perspective for Bible Study

The situational perspective focuses on the situation. This includes the historical and cultural environment to which our passage belongs. The surrounding culture and its history is not itself a norm that we are supposed to conform to. Any culture and any extended historical sequence of events is going to include both good and bad, often in complex mixtures. But a Bible passage that God gives us originally addresses people within a cultural context. For the events in [Genesis 6](#), the nearby context is the increasing wickedness of the people of the time of Noah. But the *words* of [Genesis 6](#) come from a somewhat later time, when the book of Genesis was originally written. The book of Genesis is addressed to the people of Israel. (And, as we have observed, it was written by God “for our instruction,” [Rom. 15:4](#).) The Bible comments in various ways on the context of Noah’s time and the context of the people of Israel as a nation. The Bible may ask the people to change in some way in relation to their context. If we fail to pay attention to the context, it is easy to inject our own modern meanings and our own modern context as a substitute. And then we will not get typology right—in fact, we will not get right the interpretation of any passage in the Bible.

The Existential Perspective for Bible Study

The existential perspective for Bible study tells us to pay attention to the motives of the people about whom the passages speak. But, more important, it tells us to pay attention

to our own motives. It is very easy to find ourselves trying to make the Bible say what we want it to say rather than what it does say.

The study of types is a particularly challenging area because people can easily go in one of two extreme directions. In one direction, they become so timid that they cannot see typological meaning at all. They do not see anything beyond the obvious surface. In the other direction, people can develop overheated imaginations. They find all kinds of meanings that are not really there. We saw an instance of excessive imagination in Philo of Alexandria's interpretation of [Genesis 6:9](#) (see chapter 2).

So what do we do? We must ask God for wisdom. Proverbs repeatedly stresses the value of wisdom and exhorts us to seek it:

My son, if you receive my words
and treasure up my commandments with you,
making your ear attentive to wisdom
and inclining your heart to understanding;
yes, if you call out for insight
and raise your voice for understanding,
if you seek it like silver
and search for it as for hidden treasures,
then you will understand the fear of the LORD
and find the knowledge of God.
For the LORD gives wisdom;
from his mouth come knowledge and understanding;
he stores up sound wisdom for the upright;
he is a shield to those who walk in integrity,
guarding the paths of justice
and watching over the way of his saints.
Then you will understand righteousness and justice
and equity, every good path;
for wisdom will come into your heart,
and knowledge will be pleasant to your soul;
discretion will watch over you,
understanding will guard you,
delivering you from the way of evil,
from men of perverted speech,
who forsake the paths of uprightness
to walk in the ways of darkness,

who rejoice in doing evil
and delight in the perverseness of evil,
men whose paths are crooked,
and who are devious in their ways. ([Prov. 2:1–15](#))

Wisdom, which comes from the Lord, guides us not only in just dealings with other people but also in having discretion in how we interpret the Bible.

We could add also the need for patience, for humility, and in general for the fruits of the Spirit ([Gal. 5:22–23](#)). We need patience, because a deep and sound understanding of the Bible does not come in a single moment. We are committing ourselves to a lifetime of study. This patience is needed in typology. Not all typological meanings are obvious. We have to grow in understanding the Bible as a whole.

We also need humility. We need to recognize that we are limited, especially as we face the majesty of God in reading the Bible. Not every thought that comes into our minds is directly an indication of what God actually means.
